Heuristic Evaluation

What are heuristics?

Heuristic Evaluation is part of the wider field of User Experience research methods. They are both rules of thumb and characteristics of best practice, making them good criteria to measure against.

In practice several experts, ideally on User Experience but also the subject matter, the system/software being used or a combination thereof, evaluate the usability of an interface. They do so based on a set of pre-defined criteria, or heuristics, and score how well they feel the interface meets them.

You can find out more by clicking the link below.

What is Heuristic Evaluation

Where did they come from?

As software and computing became more mainstream in the late 20th century, companies realised features alone couldn't draw in more users. As part of the wider birth of User Experience, an article was published in 1990 titled *Improving a Human-Computer Dialogue*. This contained the very first heuristics.

Below are three of the best-known Heuristic Evaluation systems - the next few slides will show some examples from each of them.

ALAN COOPER

Software should be polite

JAKOB NIELSEN

Usability heuristics

STEVE KRUG

The reservoir of goodwill

Alan Cooper

SOFTWARE SHOULD BE INTERESTED IN ME

No matter what software or tool you are creating, you need to consider all the ways it can learn more about its users.

Alan Cooper

SOFTWARE SHOULD BE FORTHCOMING

Forthcoming software shows the user all the relevant information that pertains to their current task. Often, software has a lot more information than is shown to the user.

Alan Cooper

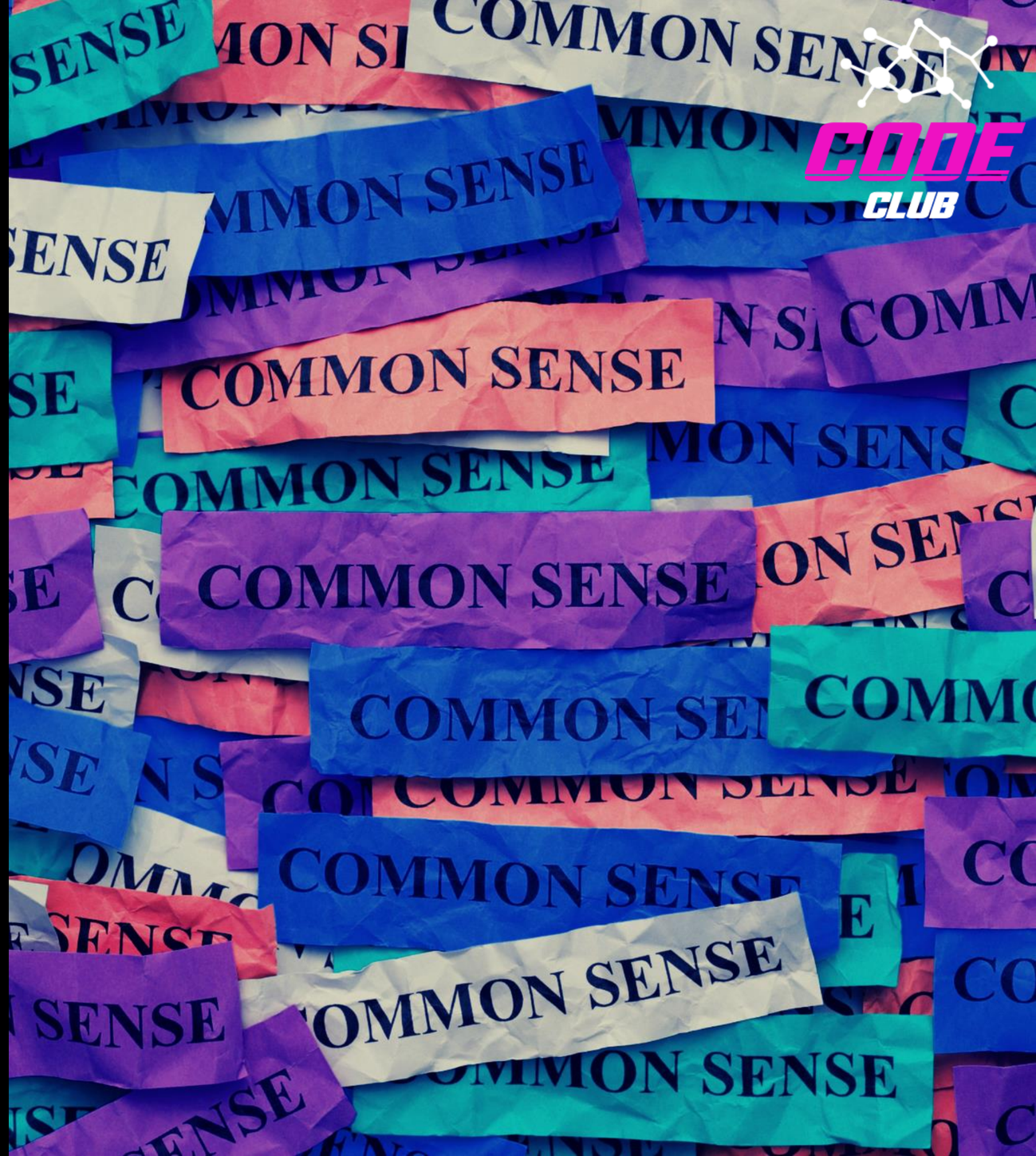
SOFTWARE SHOULD BE SELF-CONFIDENT

Software that is self-confident knows what it does and accurately conveys that to the user. It projects its confidence to the user and assures that them what they've done is correct.

Alan Cooper

SOFTWARE SHOULD HAVE COMMON SENSE

Common sense software doesn’t do pointless things, ask for unnecessary information or accept poor inputs then fail, to name a few all-too-common examples.



Jakob Nielsen

VISIBILITY OF SYSTEM STATUS

Feedback from the system to the user is of great value, preventing confusion and adding a sense of comfort.

Jakob Nielsen

MATCH BETWEEN SYSTEM AND REAL WORLD

Essentially, don’t use jargon, acronyms or metaphors that the users won’t understand. It’s your job to make sure your software speaks the same language as your customers.

Jakob Nielsen

FREEDOM AND CONTROL

People want to feel in control when using software, not constrained by it. They should not be led down dead ends where they have no power to take any further action.

Jakob Nielsen

RECOGNITION RATHER THAN RECALL

Software should encourage recognition instead of recall in users. That is because it is easier to recognise something than it is to recall relevant information.

Steve Krug

DON'T FORCE ME TO DO IT YOUR WAY

The more you force users to do things that don't make logical sense to them, but make your life a little easier, the more frustrated they get.

Steve Krug

SAVE ME STEPS WHENEVER POSSIBLE

Do not waste a user's time. Saving steps wherever possible will increase the reservoir of goodwill a user has towards your software.

So how can I measure them?

It's not as hard as it sounds but should be carried out by an expert. Make a scoring sheet, grade the software/tool and make sure to write detailed and accurate comments in explanation.

Remember that scoring them is a guide, not an exact science.

Heuristic	Score	Comments
Software should be interested in me	3/5	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet consecutor
Software should be forthcoming	4/5	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet consecutor
Software should be self-confident	2/5	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet consecutor
Software should have common sense	5/5	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet consecutor
Visibility of system status	1/5	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet consecutor
Match between system and real world	3/5	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet consecutor
Freedom and control	2/5	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet consecutor
Recognition rather than recall	3/5	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet consecutor
Don't force me to do it your way	5/5	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet consecutor
Save me steps whenever possible	4/5	Lorem ipsum dolor sit amet consecutor

More about heuristics

The benefits of heuristic evaluation

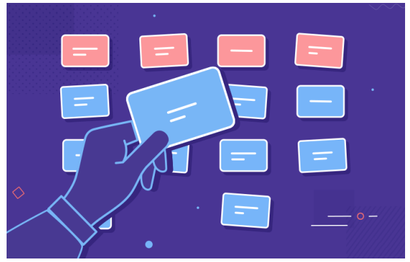
The 14 characteristics of polite software

How to conduct heuristic evaluations

Comparative study of heuristic evaluation and usability testing methods

What are my other options?

Heuristic Evaluation is just one of several ways to evaluate a user interface. Alongside its expert-focused method, here are some other approaches you could consider:



Card Sorting

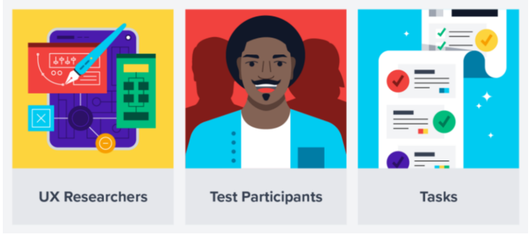
	You	Competitor 1	Competitor 2	Competitor 3
Product quality	9	1	8	5
Pricing	3	4	3	2
Place	3	7	4	8
Promotion	4	7	9	4
Positioning	6	9	7	10
Reputation	4	10	4	8
People	7	3	7	2
Partnership	8	7	8	6

Competitive Benchmarking

Depth Interviews

Stakeholder Interviews

Surveys



Usability Testing

EVERYONE
CAN CODE!